Sons', there were many issues that had to be considered. He said, 'Indeed, if we choose to go public … it is again not to grow our business, it is to attract investors.' The doubling of the income in three years in 2004 once again inevitably fuelled the debate on TCS going public. But it was evident that the final decision would be Ratan's. The decision to list or not was not an easy call to make and it was long pending. The demand, in some form or the other, had been playing out at least for a decade and a half.

Nevertheless, when the proposal to list the company came up again in the 2000s, the decision was wrenching. 'It was one of the most difficult decisions for Ratan. He was very torn,' says Hussain. But at the same time, Ratan was also uneasy that the process had taken so long. The whole issue was complicated and took time as the veterans of the group were divided on the advisability of listing. Besides, there was also the vexatious issue of taxation and others too that had to be resolved and some goals achieved before listing the company.

The opinions of veterans were varied but they covered the entire decision spectrum. One lot clamoured for the listing without delay and the second for not disturbing the status quo. The first group was led by the senior leaders of TCS, who argued that the people who built the enterprise should be given stock options and that this could not happen without listing. This was already a practice amongst software companies. Infosys, TCS's competitor, had already gone public, bringing it several benefits. The employees had to be recognized, says Ramadorai. This group also had a strong supporter in Ratan. The need to reward the employees was the main factor that persuaded Ratan to list the company. He said that the employees deserved to be given a share of the fruits of their labour. The fact that when the company is listed, it would make the Tatas the group with the highest market cap did not weigh much with Ratan. The company had the funds to grow and the freedom to 'go into the lines of business', according to its strategic plan, without listing. The main drawback of not listing was that 'employees cannot earn a piece of that company, which is something we are concerned about and we would like to find a solution for', as Ratan said in an interview to a leading newspaper.

The significance attached to higher valuation that the listing would bring to both TCS and Tata Sons was also a factor. Higher valuation was 'important' for the 'image of the group', says Soonawala. Funds were also critically needed for the modernization of some of the important Tata